



SIPRA DAS



YASBANT NEGI

PETTY POLITICS

MAY 26, 2008: The Congress-PDP government transfers 100 acres of forest land to Amarnath Shrine Board. PDP MLA and minister of forests Qazi Afzal signs the file.

JUNE 28, 2008: As the state is rocked by protests, new governor N.N. Vohra asks Azad to revoke the land transfer

JUNE 28, 2008: Coalition partner PDP withdraws support to the Congress-led government in the state over the issue

JUNE 29, 2008: Azad agrees to revoke order and does so the next day. Protests in the Valley continue.

JULY 7, 2008: Azad government resigns. The RSS-affiliated AYSS calls for an economic blockade in the region. The army is called in as links between Kashmir and the rest of India are weakened.

JULY 31, 2008: After a month of strife and economic blockade in Jammu, Sonia dials Rajnath while the PM reaches out to Advani and asks for BJP support.

AUGUST 6, 2008: A four-hour all-party meet in the capital resolves nothing but decides to send an all-party delegation to Jammu.

Meanwhile, AYSS, a conglomerate of Hindu organisations, has called for an economic blockade protesting against the decision to revoke the land transfer. The blockade against the Muslim-majority Kashmir Valley has further defined the battle as one between the Kashmir and Jammu regions, consequently choking the only surface link between Kashmir and the rest of India for about two weeks now. The situation forced the government to seek the army's assistance to ensure the unhindered movement of essential goods to Kashmir and the export of fresh fruit from the Valley. But the army has made little difference on the ground. According to an official, in 36 days of the agitation, 52 major incidents have taken place in the Jammu division which has left 102 policemen injured. The prime minister has now decided to open a direct channel of communication with the AYSS.

Trade and economics have been one of the main holding links between Kashmir and the rest of the country. However, this link has, perhaps for the first time, come under serious strain. The situation has the potential for serious political consequences since fruit growers and traders in Kashmir have threatened to cross the LoC to take their produce via Muzaffarabad in Pakistan-held Kashmir to markets outside. Vohra had to seek assurances from the Punjab government not to allow political groups in the adjacent state to aid the economic blockade against Kashmir.

After a month of calm in Kashmir, events in Jammu have triggered "look-north" thinking not just among separatists but the Kashmiri business and trader community as well. Protests have again erupted on Srinagar streets. The idea of moving Kashmiri produce via Muzaffarabad has found wide acceptance in Kashmir. This has led to fresh protests by separatists against the blockade and the alleged assaults on Muslims in Jammu have united hardline and moderate separatists who see the land transfer as a plot to settle non-local Hindus in the Valley.

The Congress knows that by trading on the Amarnath land issue, it has lost credibility with both the Hindu and the Muslim votebanks. ■

polls, each political party is playing to its votebank.

Bano mistake in which the nation was plunged into 'divisive politics' just because of a decision to please a section of a particular community. UPA had already been brought on board earlier in the day by troubleshooter-in-chief Pranab Mukherjee. Just before the all-party meeting, eight out of 10 members of the SASB handed in their resignations. This allowed the government to offer as a bargaining chip the reconstitution of a new board with "local and eminent persons inspiring the confidence of the people of Jammu and Kashmir". Congress leader Karan Singh and two other MPs from the state also asked for the governor's resignation. Mukherjee, however, has ruled out recalling Vohra.

The Amarnath issue was also raised by Mehbooba, NC chief Omar Abdullah and Advani during the recent trust vote. "Why should Jammu and Kashmir be expected to transfer land to a shrine when the government is capable of making all the arrangements?", asked Mehbooba playing to her votebank. The BJP predictably was against this flip-flop. It argued against minority appeasement and pointed out the facilities given by state and central governments to Haj pilgrims. On the other hand, the NC opposed the transfer to the SASB and instead suggested that land remain under the state government. The casualties, in all this, are the people of Jammu and Kashmir.